

UTT Chapter 06 Assignment

Hello again!

I finally have enough time to write you! Midterms were just as rough as I thought they would be. I mean, tests in high school were hard too, but these were just brutal. Anyway, intramurals are pretty much over for a little while, which is half-sad and half-relieving. Even though it was fun, it took a lot of time.

I had a funny experience today at the cafeteria! Apparently, there's a tradition at our school that everyone in the cafeteria claps when someone drops a dish. Unfortunately, today was my turn for a standing ovation. I didn't just drop a fork or spill a little soda either. I made a scene! I slipped on a wet spot and went right down onto the floor with every item from my lunch tray following. When I looked down, I was wearing my lunch. I stood up and took a bow and everyone clapped. It was pretty funny even though it was little embarrassing as well.

When I got back to my room to change, Nathan was talking on the phone with a friend of his. From what I gathered, he was giving his friend advice about some crisis he was going through. At first I thought Nathan was talking about God, but then I heard him tell his friend to spend some time meditating and "emptying his mind." I didn't catch everything Nathan said (or maybe I just didn't understand what he was saying), but I clearly heard him say "life is suffering" and that the solution to our suffering could be found within us. Nathan told his friend to practice "emptying himself" and to "reconnect with the divine consciousness." None of that seemed very comforting to me, but it made me curious.

Later I asked my friend Sarah about it. She said Nathan is into to "New Spirituality" and that he reads too much Eastern religious literature. She said it is all a bunch of . . . well, it doesn't rhyme with baloney, but it basically means the same thing!

I bet you know about Nathan's beliefs! I know it has something to do with God, but I have no idea what Nathan was saying about consciousness. **What does New Spirituality teach about God and consciousness?** It doesn't sound Christian, but then again, I'm not sure what it sounds like. **What does New Spirituality say about humanity?** And **what does New Spirituality say is wrong with us?** It sounded like meditation and "becoming one with the universe" is some kind of cure-all for problems. **What does New Spirituality say about how we should live?**

You're basically my worldview dictionary. It's pretty awesome. I hope you don't mind! I'll talk to you later. I'm meeting up with everyone in the Commons for a Ping-Pong tournament.

Bye!
-Doug

Doug brought up four different questions; below is a rough outline of possible responses:

1. What does New Spirituality teach about God and consciousness?

New Spirituality teaches that everyone and everything is interconnected with the whole of reality. **Consciousness** is the divine essence of this interconnected whole. Consciousness is god. Since everything is part of this consciousness, everything is ultimately part of god. We have come to see ourselves as unique and separate beings, but in reality separation is merely an illusion. The greater our connection with the whole, the more conscious we become of our oneness and our own divinity. God is thus something like an impersonal force that connects all of reality, rather than a personal being separate from reality. [6.5a–b]

2. What does New Spirituality say about humanity?

According to New Spirituality, consciousness is the ultimate nature of reality, not individual existence. Human beings are all connected to the divine consciousness; thus, we are all god. Consciousness has always existed, so as part of divine reality, each of us has always existed. There was an instant when we became our physical selves, but we have always existed as part of the divine whole. Our physical existence will pass away, but the divinity within is retained in the whole. Human beings are therefore god in a body. The more connected we become to consciousness, the more access we have to the divine power and knowledge within. [6.8b]

3. What does New Spirituality say is wrong with us?

According to New Spirituality, the problem with humanity is not that we are hopelessly fallen and in need of savior. The problem with humanity is that we are unaware of our own divinity, that is, we don't understand the true nature of consciousness. The suffering we all observe and experience is not the product of evil; suffering is the result of our unenlightened state of being. We can't become good people by trying to do good works; we become good by connecting with the goodness already inside of us and allowing it to flourish. Organized religion has led us to believe that sin is our struggle. However, recognizing and overcoming our own ignorance is the key to improving our predicament. [6.8c]

4. What does New Spirituality say about how we should live?

Christians believe that we have a duty to help those who are suffering. But according to New Spirituality, compassion toward others merely prolongs suffering. As New Spiritualists see it, at least in its Eastern forms, suffering helps cleanse one's negative karma. According to the law of **karma**, if we did something evil in a past life, we must atone for our actions through suffering

in this life. When Christians try to alleviate the suffering of others, they are merely prolonging it. Similarly, the law of attraction states that negative thoughts attract negative outcomes. If someone is poor or in pain, it is likely because they are fixated on being poor or in pain. If you want to be free of suffering, you need to rid yourself of negative thoughts and strive to overcome your individualism. By paying our karmic debts, concentrating on positive thoughts, and achieving higher states of consciousness, we rid ourselves of misery. [6.8d]